490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 8 OF 26

The Exodus and the Passover Lamb

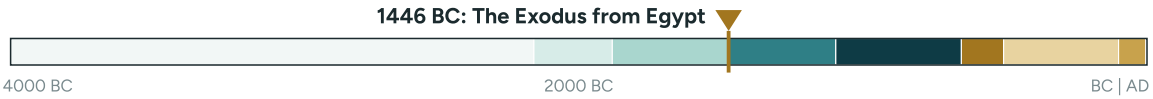
Exodus 1–15



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 8



Introduction: The Night Everything Changed

Every family has a story it tells again and again. How Grandpa came over on the boat. The night the house burned and everyone got out. The story gets told at holidays until the children can recite it, because it explains who the family is.

Israel has a story like that, and the Bible tells it in the book of Exodus (the word means "the way out"). A nation of slaves in Egypt. A night of judgment. A lamb in every house and its blood on every door. A sea that opened and closed. For more than three thousand years God's people have kept the Passover, and to this day Jewish families retell the story every spring. In a custom that goes back to the early centuries after Christ, the youngest child asks, "Why is this night different from all other nights?" Exodus itself expected that question (12:26). Jesus himself kept the Passover with his disciples on the night before he died. And then he gave the story a new center.

This lesson opens Unit 3, "Rescue and Covenant." We have come a long way. In Lesson 6, God told Abraham that his family would be "sojourners in a land that is not theirs and will be servants there, and they will be afflicted for four hundred years," and that afterward God would bring them out (Gen. 15:13–14). In Lesson 7 we watched Jacob's family of seventy move down to Egypt to survive a famine. The family has grown into a nation, and the prophecy has come true. They are slaves. This lesson runs from Moses' birth, about 1526 BC, to the night Israel walked out of Egypt in 1446 BC, when Moses was eighty (7:7).

The Word: Passover

> **Exodus 12:12–13** *"For I will pass through the land of Egypt that night, and I will strike all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, both man and beast; and on all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgments: I am the LORD. The blood shall be a sign for you, on the houses where you are. And when I see the blood, I will pass over you, and no plague will befall you to destroy you, when I strike the land of Egypt."*

פֶּסַח *(pesaḥ, "Passover")*

from the verb "to pass over," to spare

פָּסַח (pasaḥ)

"to pass over"

What God promised to do at the houses marked with blood: "I will pass over you" (12:13). Isaiah uses it of God shielding his city (Isa. 31:5).

→

פֶּסַח (pesaḥ)

"the Passover"

The name for the lamb, the meal, and the feast. "Kill the Passover lamb" (12:21). "It is the LORD's Passover" (12:11).

Payoff: The same word names both what God does and the lamb that makes it possible. God "passes over" the house because of the "Passover," the lamb whose blood is on the door. Judgment came to every house in Egypt that night. In the Egyptian houses, the firstborn died. In the Israelite houses, a lamb had already died. The New Testament takes this word and puts a name on it: "For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed" (1 Cor. 5:7).

Part One: Slaves in Egypt



"So they ruthlessly made the people of Israel work as slaves and made their lives bitter with hard service, in mortar and brick" (Ex. 1:13–14).

Exodus opens with a sentence that changes everything: "Now there arose a new king over Egypt, who did not know Joseph" (Ex. 1:8). Joseph had saved Egypt. Now Joseph's people were seen as a threat. Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, enslaved them and set taskmasters over them "to afflict them with heavy burdens" (1:11). When that did not shrink their numbers, he ordered the Hebrew midwives to kill every baby boy at birth. But two brave women, Shiphrah and Puah, "feared God and did not do as the king of Egypt commanded them" (1:17). So Pharaoh commanded all his people, "Every son that is born to the Hebrews you shall cast into the Nile" (1:22).

Into that world a baby boy was born to a family from the tribe of Levi, one of Jacob's twelve sons (2:1). His mother hid him for three months, then placed him in a basket among the reeds of the Nile, and Pharaoh's own daughter found him and raised him as her son. She named him Moses (2:1–10). Raised in the palace, Moses was "instructed in all the wisdom of the Egyptians" (Acts 7:22). At forty, he tried to defend his people by killing an Egyptian, and had to flee to the desert of Midian, where he spent the next forty years as a shepherd (Ex. 2:11–15; Acts 7:23, 30).

Meanwhile, back in Egypt: "the people of Israel groaned because of their slavery and cried out for help. Their cry for rescue from slavery came up to God. And God heard their groaning, and God remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob" (2:23–24). God saw his people, and God knew (2:25). Notice the verbs: God heard, God remembered, God saw, God knew. In Lesson 2 we stood with Moses at the burning bush and heard God's name, I AM. Before God gave that name, he told Moses why he had come: "I have surely seen the affliction of my people who are in Egypt and have heard their cry because of their taskmasters. I know their sufferings, and I have come down to deliver them" (3:7–8).

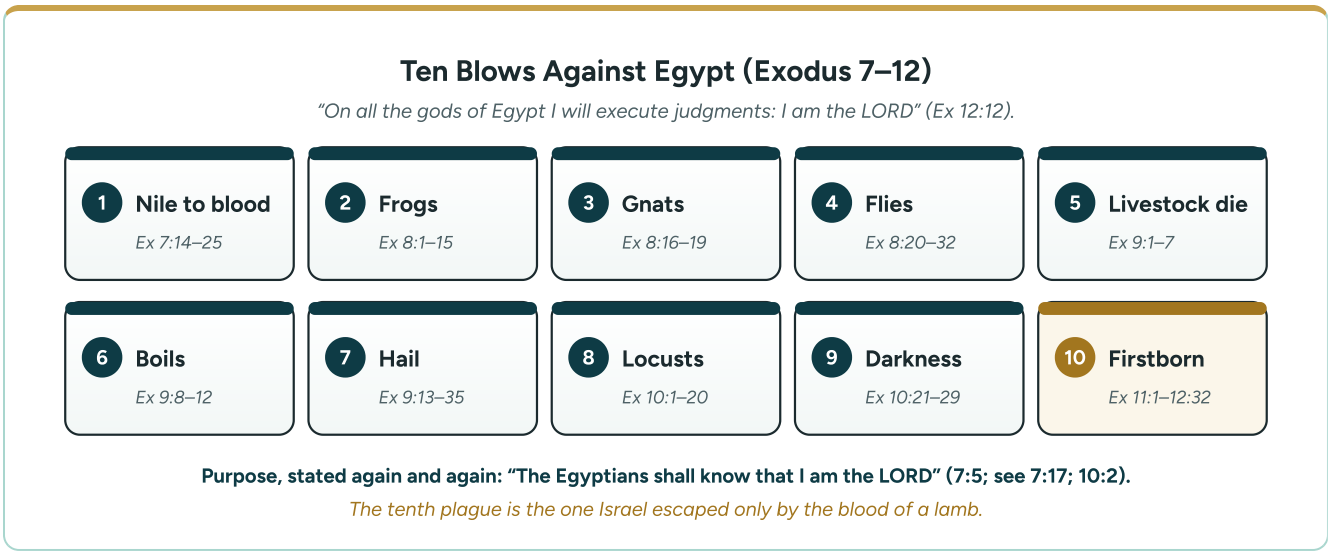
And God sent one of the most reluctant rescuers in the Bible. "Who am I that I should go to Pharaoh?" Moses asked (3:11). He made excuse after excuse until he finally begged, "Oh, my Lord, please send someone else" (4:13). God sent him anyway, with his brother Aaron to help him speak. The rescue would rest on God, whatever Moses lacked.

Part Two: "Let My People Go"

Moses and Aaron walked into Pharaoh's court with God's message: "Let my people go, that they may hold a feast to me in the wilderness" (5:1). Later, it was put even more plainly: "Let my people go, that they may serve me" (7:16). The word "serve" here is the same Hebrew word Exodus used for their slavery (1:13–14). God was bringing them out of hard service to Pharaoh and into glad service to the God who loved them.

Pharaoh answered with contempt: "Who is the LORD, that I should obey his voice and let Israel go? I do not know the LORD" (5:2). What followed were ten plagues, ten blows of judgment on Egypt. The Nile turned to blood. Frogs, gnats, and flies swarmed the land. The livestock died. Boils broke out. Hail destroyed the crops, and locusts ate what the hail missed. Darkness covered Egypt for three days. And finally, the death of the firstborn.

Why the firstborn? In the ancient world the firstborn son was the heir, the one who carried the family's name and future. Before the plagues began, God had told Moses what to say to Pharaoh: "Israel is my firstborn son, and I say to you, 'Let my son go that he may serve me.' If you refuse to let him go, behold, I will kill your firstborn son" (4:22–23). Pharaoh had been crushing God's son for generations. The last plague was justice, announced long in advance, and Pharaoh was warned again and again. God also made a distinction: from the fourth plague on, the land where Israel lived was spared (8:22–23; 11:7). On the last night, though, the line between Egypt and Israel would not hold by itself. Israel's firstborn were sinners too. Only the blood would keep them.



Why ten plagues? Why not one? Because God was answering Pharaoh's question, "Who is the LORD?" Egypt worshiped many gods: gods of the Nile, of the sun, of the land's fertility, and Pharaoh himself was honored as divine. God said, "on all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgments: I am the LORD" (12:12). Plague by plague, everything Egypt trusted was shown to be powerless before the one true God. The purpose was stated again and again: "By this you shall know that I am the LORD" (7:17; see 7:5; 8:22; 10:2).

You will also notice something that troubles many readers: Pharaoh's heart was hardened. Sometimes the text says Pharaoh "hardened his heart" (8:15). Other times it says "the LORD hardened the heart of Pharaoh" (9:12). Both are true. Pharaoh was fully responsible; he refused God again and again. And God, who rules over all things, had said before the first plague, "I will harden his heart" (4:21). He put no evil into Pharaoh. He withheld the mercy that would have softened him, gave him over to the hardness he loved, and used it for his own purposes. Paul quotes God's words to Pharaoh: "For this very purpose I have raised you up, that I might show my power in you, and that my name might be proclaimed in all the earth" (Rom. 9:17; see Ex. 9:16). It is the same truth we saw with Joseph's brothers in Lesson 7. People mean their evil. God rules over it, and he is never its author.

Part Three: The Lamb and the Blood

Before the last plague, God gave Israel instructions for a meal unlike any other. On the tenth day of the month, every household was to choose a lamb: "Your lamb shall be without blemish, a male a year old" (12:5). They kept it for four days, and on the fourteenth day, at twilight, every family killed its lamb. Then they took a bundle of hyssop (a small leafy plant), dipped it in the blood, and painted it on the two doorposts and the top beam of the door (12:7, 22). They roasted the lamb and ate it that night with unleavened bread (bread made without yeast, a sign of the haste of that night, 12:11, 39) and bitter herbs, which echo how Egypt "made their lives bitter" (1:14). And they ate dressed for a journey: "with your belt fastened, your sandals on your feet, and your staff in your hand. And you shall eat it in haste. It is the LORD's Passover" (12:11).

At midnight, the judgment fell. "The LORD struck down all the firstborn in the land of Egypt, from the firstborn of Pharaoh who sat on his throne to the firstborn of the captive who was in the dungeon… there was not a house where someone was not dead" (12:29–30). But in the houses marked with blood, the LORD passed over.

Take a moment with this, because it is the heart of the lesson. Were the Israelite families saved because they were better people than the Egyptians? No. They had turned on Moses and would not listen to him (5:21; 6:9), and many of them clung to the idols of Egypt (Ezek. 20:7–8; Josh. 24:14). The destroyer (12:23) did not pass over the houses of good people. He passed over the houses with blood on the door. That night God asked one question of every house: is there blood on the door? A lamb had died in that house, in place of the firstborn.

That night Pharaoh finally broke. "Up, go out from among my people… and go, serve the LORD" (12:31). After 430 years in Egypt, "on that very day, all the hosts of the LORD went out from the land of Egypt" (12:40–41). That number fits our timeline: Jacob's family came down around 1876 BC, and Israel came out in 1446 BC. Genesis gave the round number, four hundred; Exodus gives the exact one.

Israel did not leave alone. About six hundred thousand men walked out, besides women and children, and "a mixed multitude also went up with them" (12:37–38). Some Egyptians and other foreigners had seen enough of the LORD to throw in their lot with his people. God made room for them at the table: any foreigner who joined Israel and received the covenant sign could keep the Passover, and "he shall be as a native of the land" (12:48). Even on the night of the Exodus, God's rescue was wider than one bloodline. What mattered was being under the blood, among his people.

God commanded Israel to keep the Passover every year, forever, so their children would ask, "What do you mean by this service?" and they would answer, "It is the sacrifice of the LORD's Passover, for he passed over the houses of the people of Israel in Egypt" (12:26–27). They were also to set apart every firstborn son to God and "redeem" him, buy him back with a payment, because on Passover night the LORD killed Egypt's firstborn and spared Israel's (13:2, 13–15). Every firstborn in Israel grew up knowing he belonged to God because of the night of the lamb.

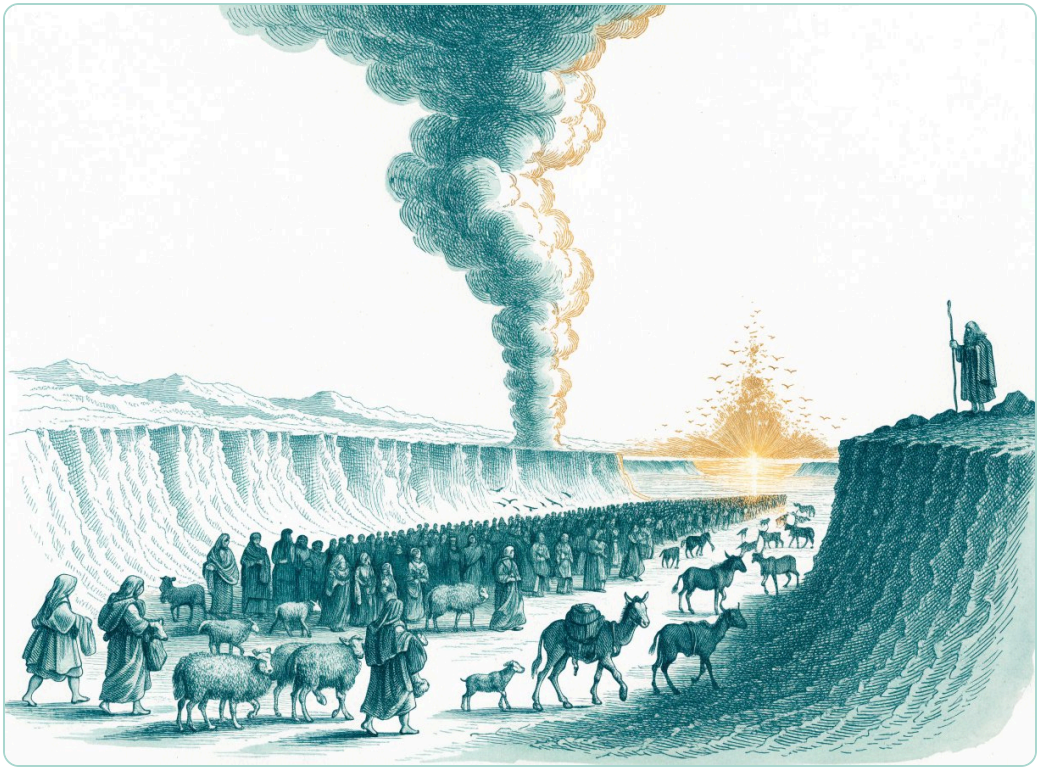
The Passover and Christ, Our Passover Lamb

	Exodus 12		Jesus
A lamb without blemish	"without blemish, a male a year old" (12:5)	→	"a lamb without blemish or spot" (1 Pet 1:19)
It died in their place	the firstborn lived because the lamb died	→	"Christ died for us" (Rom 5:8)
Blood on the door	"when I see the blood, I will pass over" (12:13)	→	"justified by his blood" (Rom 5:9)
No bone broken	"you shall not break any of its bones" (12:46)	→	"Not one of his bones will be broken" (John 19:36)
A meal of the covenant	"a statute… forever" (12:24)	→	"the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20)
Out of slavery	out of Egypt, "the house of slavery" (13:14)	→	"free indeed" from sin (John 8:36)

"For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed" (1 Cor 5:7).

Part Four: Through the Sea

God led Israel out, and he went with them in a visible way: "the LORD went before them by day in a pillar of cloud to lead them along the way, and by night in a pillar of fire to give them light" (13:21). But he led them to a dead end. With the sea in front of them and Pharaoh's chariots charging up behind (Pharaoh had changed his mind again, and the LORD had hardened his heart, 14:5, 8), the people panicked: "Is it because there are no graves in Egypt that you have taken us away to die in the wilderness?" (14:11).



"The people of Israel went into the midst of the sea on dry ground, the waters being a wall to them on their right hand and on their left" (Ex. 14:22).

And Moses spoke one of the great sentences of faith: "Fear not, stand firm, and see the salvation of the LORD, which he will work for you today… The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent" (14:13–14). Then Moses stretched out his hand, "and the LORD drove the sea back by a strong east wind all night and made the sea dry land, and the waters were divided. And the people of Israel went into the midst of the sea on dry ground" (14:21–22). When the Egyptian army followed, the waters returned and covered them.

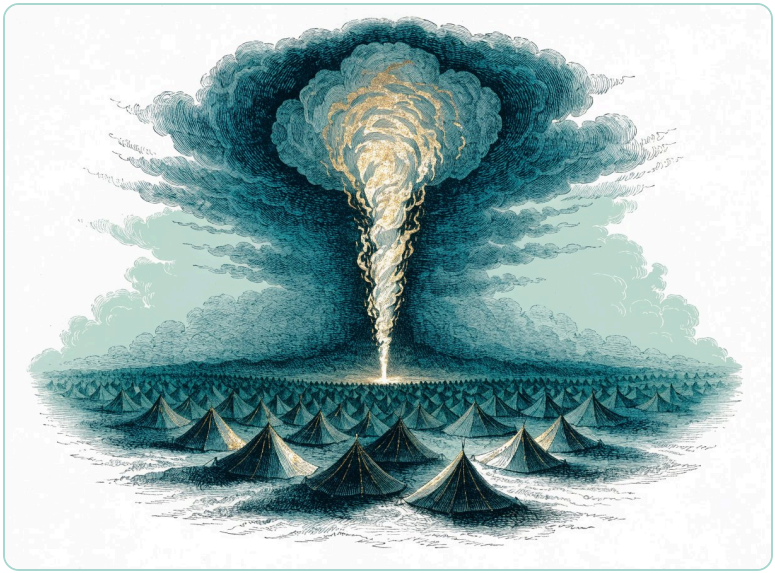
"Thus the LORD saved Israel that day… so the people feared the LORD, and they believed in the LORD and in his servant Moses" (14:30–31). Then they sang, the first song of praise to God in the Bible: "I will sing to the LORD, for he has triumphed gloriously; the horse and his rider he has thrown into the sea. The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation" (15:1–2).

Notice what Israel did to save themselves. Nothing. They stood still, and they walked through on ground God dried for them. That is the shape of *salvation* all through the Bible. God does the rescuing, and his people receive it by faith: "By faith the people crossed the Red Sea as on dry land" (Heb. 11:29). And notice the word God had used for it back in chapter 6: "I will redeem you with an outstretched arm and with great acts of judgment" (6:6). To *redeem* is to set a captive free, often by paying a price. The Exodus is the Old Testament's great picture of redemption. From now on, whenever the prophets want to describe how God saves, they reach back to this story.

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE For the first time since Eden, God traveled visibly with his people, in the pillar of cloud and fire that "did not depart from before the people" (Ex. 13:22). And their song on the far shore looks ahead to where he is leading them: "You will bring them in and plant them on your own mountain, the place, O LORD, which you have made for your abode, the sanctuary, O Lord, which your hands have established" (15:17). Two lessons from now, God will move in.

THE LAMB This is where the thread becomes a rope. A spotless lamb's blood on the door turns judgment aside. "Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed" (1 Cor. 5:7). We were ransomed "with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot" (1 Pet. 1:19).



"The pillar of cloud by day and the pillar of fire by night did not depart from before the people" (Ex. 13:22).

The Turn: Our Passover Lamb

Fifteen centuries later, Jesus sat down with his disciples in Jerusalem to eat the Passover. He said, "I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer" (Luke 22:15). They were eating the meal that remembered the lamb whose blood saved Israel's firstborn. And during that meal, Jesus took the bread and said, "This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me." He took the cup and said, "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:19–20). In one evening he took Israel's great meal of rescue and showed them it had always been about him. Christians still keep the meal Jesus gave that night, called the Lord's Supper or Communion. Jesus took the Passover's bread and cup and made them signs of the new covenant in his blood. When believers eat and drink in faith, they remember, and they also receive. The bread stays bread, yet Christ by his Spirit truly feeds our souls with himself and all the benefits of his death (1 Cor. 10:16; WSC 96).

A few hours later, on that same day by Jewish reckoning (their days began at sundown), during the Passover feast, Jesus was crucified. The soldiers broke the legs of the two men crucified beside him, but when they came to Jesus he was already dead, so they did not break his legs. John says this happened "that the Scripture might be fulfilled: 'Not one of his bones will be broken'" (John 19:36), the very rule God gave for the Passover lamb (Ex. 12:46). When Moses and Elijah (a great prophet we will meet later) appeared with Jesus on a mountain where his glory shone out, they talked about "his departure, which he was about to accomplish at Jerusalem" (Luke 9:31). The Greek word is *exodos*. Jesus' death, resurrection, and return to the Father were the true Exodus.

Every one of us was born a slave, though not to Pharaoh. Jesus said, "everyone who practices sin is a slave to sin… So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed" (John 8:34, 36). And apart from Christ, every one of us lives under God's just judgment. There is only one question that matters on the night of judgment: is there blood on the door? Your goodness will not answer it, and neither will your religious record. Only the blood of the Lamb will. "Since, therefore, we have now been justified by his blood, much more shall we be saved by him from the wrath of God" (Rom. 5:9). (To be *justified* is to be declared right with God, as Abraham was when he believed.)

So come in under the blood. Turn from your sin and trust Jesus, the Lamb without blemish who died in your place. Then, like Israel on the far shore, you will have a song to sing: "The LORD is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation." And at the very end of the Bible, the redeemed stand by another sea and sing "the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb" (Rev. 15:3).

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the story.** Read Exodus 1–3, 12, and 14–15. Read chapter 12 slowly, twice.

2. **Ask the Passover question.** If someone asked you, "What does Jesus' death mean to you?" could you answer the way Israel answered their children? Write two sentences.

3. **Name your Egypt.** What sin or habit still enslaves you? Bring it to the Son who sets people "free indeed."

4. **Be still.** When you face a sea you cannot cross this week, pray Exodus 14:14: "The LORD will fight for you, and you have only to be silent."

5. **Come to the table.** The next time your church celebrates the Lord's Supper, remember the Passover lamb and the blood on the door, and come expecting Christ to strengthen your faith.

6. **Memorize 1 Corinthians 5:7.** "For Christ, our Passover lamb, has been sacrificed."

Before Lesson 9: *Read Exodus 19–20 and 24. Lesson 9 takes us to Mount Sinai, where the rescued people meet their God and receive his law.*

For Discussion

1. Why do you think God waited four hundred years to rescue Israel? What does Exodus 2:23–25 tell you about God while they waited?
2. Moses gave excuse after excuse. Which of his excuses sounds most like you? How did God answer him?
3. “Let my people go, that they may serve me.” How does that change the way you think about freedom?
4. Pharaoh hardened his heart, and God hardened Pharaoh’s heart. How can both be true? Why does it matter that we keep both?
5. On Passover night, the only question was, “Is there blood on the door?” Why is that such good news for people who know they are not good enough?
6. Look at the Passover and Christ diagram. Which connection surprises you most?
7. Israel was saved by standing still and walking through on ground God dried. Where are you trying to save yourself instead of trusting God to fight for you?

Sources & For Further Study

- On נָסַע and נֹסַע: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*; Koehler and Baumgartner, *HALOT*, s.v.
- On the date of the Exodus: 1 Kings 6:1 and Exodus 12:40–41, as set out in Lesson 1.
- Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), 5.6 (on God’s hardening of the wicked) and 29 (the Lord’s Supper). Westminster Shorter Catechism, Q. 96 (the Lord’s Supper).
- For further reading: Philip Graham Ryken, *Exodus: Saved for God’s Glory* (Preaching the Word); Alec Motyer, *The Message of Exodus* (The Bible Speaks Today).



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